

Virtual characters

- Appearing on our screens in the form of:
 - Sales agents, characters in videogames, learning companions, wizards, pets, newsreaders
- Provides a persona that is welcoming, has personality and makes user feel involved with them

Disadvantages

- Can lead people into false sense of belief, enticing them to confide personal secrets with chatterbots
- Annoying and frustrating
 - e.g. Clippy
- May not be trustworthy
 - virtual shop assistants?

What makes a virtual agent believable?

- Believability refers to the extent to which users come to believe an agent's intentions and personality
- Appearance is very important
 - Are simple cartoon-like characters or more realistic characters, resembling the human form more believable?
- Behaviour is very important
 - How an agent moves, gestures and refers to objects on the screen
 - Exaggeration of facial expressions and gestures to show underlying emotions (c.f. animation industry)

Virtual agents

- What do the virtual agents do?
- Do they elicit an emotional response in you?
- Do you trust them?
- What is the style of interaction?
- What facial expression do they have?
- Are they believable, pushy, helpful?
- Would it be different if they were male? If so, how?

Robot-like or cuddly?

- Which do you prefer and why?



(a)



(b)

Figure 5.14 Two kinds of robot pets

Source: (a) Courtesy of Sony Corporation, (b) Reproduced with permission of Steve Yohanan. Photo: Martin Dee.

Implications

- Should we create products that adapt according to people's different emotional states?
 - When people are feeling angry should an interface be more attentive and informative than when they are happy?
- Is Norman right?
 - designers “can get away with more” for products intended to be used during leisure time than those designed for serious tasks